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ACTOR PART BOOK

# Madame Pace

*the businesswoman of shame*

*Six Characters in Search of an Author*

*Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922*

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

5 SPEECHES · 566 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY

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## WHO MADAME PACE IS

**Madame Pace is the seventh Character — and now her own performer.** Pirandello marks her as the one figure not among the original Six, conjured onto the stage by its very arrangement: the hats on the pegs, the shop window the Property Man has set up (the sign reads *robes et manteaux*), the folding screen. In this edition she is no longer doubled by one of the Players; a single actor carries her and nothing else, so that when the door upstage opens and she walks through it, the audience meets a person who was not in the room a moment ago and cannot say how she got there. That is the Pirandellian trick, restored: not an actor stepping into a costume in view of the house, but an apparition who simply *is* there.

She is an Italian-Swiss immigrant who runs an atelier off the rue de Bourg in Lausanne — fat, bleach-blonde, rouged, dressed in comical black silk with a long silver chain at her waist ending in a pair of scissors. Half Italian, half French, ridiculous and grotesque. She is a businesswoman of shame: elegant, practical, smiling, and morally rotten. She does not shout — her danger comes from being calm. Play the comedy of her accent at full strength on her arrival; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength by her exit. The audience laughs when she enters, and is disgusted with itself for having laughed by the time she leaves — that double sensation is the point of her. **Do not let her become an accent joke.** The accent is the entrance. The bookkeeping is the body of her.

The casting note for the audition room: this is the production's most theatrically demanding role, and it lives entirely in one scene. Cast for an actor with the physical control to land both ends of her — comic on arrival, chilling on exit — and the discipline to hold a smile that never drops while everything underneath it turns. The wig and the silver chain do half the work; the body and the voice do the rest. The accent must be performed with no protective irony. The audience must believe both that she is the funniest thing they have seen all night and that she is the most frightening. That is the role's range.

## THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

**What it is.** Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

**This production.** Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen.** One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

**How it opens.** The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

## HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

# Act One — The Family

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## **PART I**   *The Rehearsal*

MADAME PACE DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

## **PART II**   *The Interruption*

MADAME PACE DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

## **PART III**   *The Bargain*

MADAME PACE DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

# Act Two — The Theatre

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## PART I *The Setup*

MADAME PACE DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

## PART II *The Apparition*

5 SPEECHES · 566 WORDS

*The door at the back of stage opens and MADAME PACE enters and takes a few steps forward. She is a fat, oldish woman with puffy oxygenated hair, rouged and powdered, dressed with a comical elegance in black silk. Round her waist is a long silver chain from which hangs a pair of scissors. The audience should read her at first as absurd — an apparition out of a comic operetta, conjured from the costume department of every small shop in Lausanne that has ever overcharged a foreigner. She has come, however, from somewhere real: a back room off the rue de Bourg, where the accounts book lies open on a desk and a customer is waiting. The comedy is her front. The scissors at her waist are not. The STEP-DAUGHTER runs over to her at once amid the stupor of the actors.*

*But the scene between the STEP-DAUGHTER and MADAME PACE has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of THE FATHER. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by THE FATHER, turn round and see MADAME PACE, who has placed one hand under the STEP-DAUGHTER'S chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.*

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

**MADAME PACE** *[coming forward with an air of great importance, hand pressed to her chest, very pleased indeed to be here].* Good afternoon, good afternoon, sir! Here I am, here I am — so sorry I am late, so sorry — the traffic, the trams in this town, always the same. *[A small bow to the room; the silver chain at her waist swings once.]* Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg, the courtyard near Saint-François. You know me. All Lausanne, it know me. Forty years. Forty years in this canton, sir, and never one bad word about Pace. *[Smiling, the smile of a hostess at her own front door.]* I no wanta be hard, eh? I no wanta take advantage. I am a good woman, sir. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Only — the lady over there, she ruin the silk. Again. The third time this month, sir — the third time. Silk, sir, you no pay with the tears. Somebody must pay. The mother, she pay with the hands — or the little one, she pay. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Either way, sir — the book, she balance. Pace, she always balance the book.

*Note. MADAME PACE speaks in a heavy accent, not in another language — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in French Lausanne too long and not long enough. The foreignness lives in the music of the voice and the broken grammar; the page keeps the words plain and lets the actor carry the sound. Played for full comedy on her arrival; played for full chill by her exit. The audience must laugh at her first line. They must regret laughing by her last.*

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... way she talks — that accent of hers! Most comical it is!

**MADAME PACE.** It seem not very polite, gentlemen, to laugh at me — when I try to speak proper for the customers. My customers — eh — they no laugh, sir. They come back. Wednesday afternoon. Friday afternoon. Sometimes the Sunday, after the church. *[A small shrug, the smile.]* Like the bells of Saint-François. You hear those bells, sir, in this town? Three time a week. *Bom. Bom. Bom.*

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old gentleman, eh, Madame?

**MADAME PACE.** Not so old, my dear. Not so old. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir? The best age, my dear, in my long experience. He clean. He polite. *[The smile, unchanged.]* He pay cash. The blue envelope on the little mahogany table, you no even gotta look at his face, you no even gotta count. The polite ones, sir — they count for you. He no ask your name. He no need to. He call you little one, he call you dear, he call you whatever please him — for that little while the name belong to him. *[The smile.]* And if you no like him? Eh — no scandal. Nobody talk. It stay quiet, like everything in this town. Like the silk. Like the sewing. Like everything that get ruin in Pace's shop. The lady know. The lady stay quiet too.

*Meanwhile, the STEP-DAUGHTER, coming forward again, turns to MADAME PACE.*

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Come on, Madame, come on!

**MADAME PACE** *[offended, but not loud — the offense of a businesswoman whose house rules have been questioned].* Eh no, thank you. The mother present — it is not possible, sir. It is against the rule. I have my method. I have had my method for forty years. The mother she stay in the kitchen with the tea, like always. The little one she come down the corridor when Pace she ring the little bell. *[Lifts a hand, as if to a small invisible bell.]* The business it no close while the mother she watch. The chickens too, sir. Even the chickens — you no kill them where the hen can see. The hen, she scream. The hen, she ruin the meat. It is a rule of the house. House rule. Pace, she keep the house rules.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! You can go!

**MADAME PACE** *[adjusting the silver chain at her waist; the scissors swing once].* Yes yes, of course. I go. I go. But my dear — you remember. Without Pace, nothing. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty, your little sister at home crying for the bread that is not in the house. You owe it all to me. To Pace. *[Pauses at the door. The smile returned, calm now, almost tender.]* And when the lady ruin the next silk — and she will, my dear, she always do — you know where to find me. *[Beat. The voice softer, the smile unchanged.]* There is always the next silk, my dear. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. *[The scissors swing once more at her waist.]* Don't you forget the name. *[Exits. Not furious. Unhurried.]*

### **PART III**    *The Substitution*

MADAME PACE DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

# Act Three — The Question

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## **PART I**   *The Trap*

MADAME PACE DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

## **PART II**   *The Refusal*

MADAME PACE DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

## **PART III**   *The Fountain*

MADAME PACE DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

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*Village Players · Lausanne · Madame Pace part book · lines and actions pulled from the Director's Copy.*